

One Choice Changes Everything

CHOOSE YOUR WORK



Redefine Success and Discover the Work
That Makes You Feel Fully Alive

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The Unexpected Gifts Hidden in Your Struggles

How to extract insights from your greatest challenges so they become pathways for growth.

What Do the Leaning Tower of Pisa, Improvised Jazz, and Japanese Pottery Have in Common?

The Leaning Tower of Pisa was created by accident. A mistake made during its construction in 1173 caused the tower to tilt. In fact, the defective structural design had to be stabilized from a 5.5-degree tilt to a 3.97-degree tilt in the 1990s for safety reasons. Yet this unintentional defect has become one of its most celebrated features, drawing visitors from around the world. The defect created the beauty.

When musicians play improvised jazz, by definition, they do not follow the notes on the score. We delight in the new melodies formed by the deviation from the planned composition.

Imagine a shattered teacup, not discarded, but painstakingly pieced back together, the cracks filled with shimmering gold. This is *kintsugi*, a practice in Japanese pottery that sees beauty in imperfections. Instead of hiding the flaws, they are accentuated, creating a unique and beautiful piece of art.

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The Leaning Tower of Pisa, improvised jazz, and the Japanese art of *kintsugi* highlight how there is beauty in the unexpected, the irregular, the interruption of the pattern. You are no different. Your specific challenges are a high-definition image of your authenticity. No one else has experienced your difficulties with the level of detail and clarity that you have. Your challenges contain seeds of brilliance that you can use to create distinctive work.

The challenging experiences that leave you feeling shattered are not meant to be hidden. Just as the *kintsugi* artisan carefully restores each crack, you too can pick up the fragments of your past and begin the process of golden repair.

Just as a jazz musician is valued for their unique melodies, you too will find success by tackling issues connected to your personal struggles. The first step is to recognize that you are not your work.



Figure 2: The practice of kintsugi accentuates flaws by filling them with gold.
View and download this photo in full color at:
ChooseYourWorkBook.com/kintsugi

You Are Not Your Work

The most common reaction that people have when they think back to emotionally challenging experiences is, “Oh, I just wasn’t good enough.”

That’s very different from writing an article and wondering, “Is this a high-quality article?” This is a great question to ask because it will help you identify the criteria for high-quality work. By knowing these criteria, you will write a better article.

Observe the difference between “Is this a high-quality article?” and “Am I a good writer?” When you ask the latter question, you might hesitate and lower your self-worth. This leads to a feeling of despair. Instead of facing challenges and giving them your best shot, you get swept up in a mixture of overthinking and insecurity.

So how do we separate the two? Challenge the quality of your work, but never challenge your self-worth. At your core, you are whole. Nothing can diminish your inherent value.

You can further improve the quality of your work by changing “Is this a high-quality article?” to “What could make this article better?” This more specific approach avoids the heightened emotion connected to the vague “This is great” versus “This is terrible.” Your most perceptive insights emerge when you sit behind the article and contemplate both its strengths and weaknesses. Notice how this has everything to do with the article and nothing to do with you.

In the same way that you separate the quality of your work from the quality of yourself, it is equally important to distinguish between what happened in the past and who you are today. You are not your work. You are not your profession. You are not the situations you have encountered. You are something far greater.

In light of this separation, let’s now examine what happens if you fail to confront your past challenges.

The Problem with Ignoring a Challenging Experience

When I was working in the corporate world, I was emotionally disconnected from my work. My initial discomfort wasn't a sharp pain that was strong enough to compel change. Instead, it was more like a dull, recurring ache, the kind that lingers in the background and slowly wears you down. A persistent gray fog, absent of both joy and sadness, settled over my daily lukewarm mediocrity.

Some people suffer their entire lives with this familiar discomfort to the point that they stop noticing it. I eventually realized that when I numbed myself to one feeling, I actually numbed myself to all feelings. By failing to engage with my emotions, I was trapped in a maze of indecision, constantly second-guessing my choices and desires.

When you ignore your feelings, you are more likely to get stuck in unsatisfying work. The only thing worse than doing unsatisfying work is pretending that it's not a problem.

When you notice pain, feel the pain. When you notice joy, feel the joy.

Think back to a time in your past that was both emotionally intense and difficult to navigate. Pause to recall the specific sensations that you remember experiencing. Only by fully feeling the moment can you comprehend its larger significance.

Here is a series of comparisons by psychologist Steven C. Hayes to help you feel an experience more fully. For each comparison, pause long enough to connect it to a challenging experience.

Hold your experience like a delicate flower in your hand.

Embrace your experience like a crying child.

Sit with your experience like you would sit with a person with a serious illness.

Look at your experience like you would look at an incredible painting.

Walk with your experience like you'd walk while carrying a sobbing infant.

THE UNEXPECTED GIFTS HIDDEN IN YOUR STRUGGLES

Honor your experience like you'd honor a friend by listening carefully even if it was hard.

Inhale your experience the way you would take a deep breath.

Abandon the fight like a soldier putting down the weapon and walking home.

Take in your experience like a glass of pure cold water.

Carry your experience like a picture in your wallet.

In business, I've faced several setbacks. These comparisons have been invaluable in helping me to peacefully reconnect with a challenging experience, reframe it, and gain clarity. They have helped me realize that compassion is not just important for the sake of being kind to others. We are all grappling with our own internal struggles. By recognizing that most people are doing the best they can with what they have, compassion helps you to see more clearly.

Now that you have felt your challenging experience more fully, the next step is to let it go.

The Rock Concert

We're now going to transform your challenging experience into something new by doing an activity together.

Take a moment to revisit the experience and concentrate on a specific feeling it evokes. It could be anxiety — the tension or unease from a perceived threat. Maybe it's sadness — a heaviness or sorrow weighing on your mind. You might feel anger — a sense of resentment or irritation toward a situation or a certain person. Perhaps it's guilt — the feeling of responsibility for something that went wrong. Or maybe it's disappointment — the letdown when expectations are not met. Whichever emotion you notice, allow yourself to feel it fully for ten seconds.

Imagine you're standing in front of the stage at a rock concert, close enough to touch the performers. You don't just hear the music; you feel it reverberating through every bone in your body. The pounding bass

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echoes in your chest as the scent of smoke and sweat mingles in the air around you. Strobe lights flash intensely, painting the crowd in rapid, fleeting bursts of color.

This rock concert is a metaphor for your challenging experience — intense, overwhelming, and transformative. Don't engage with any words or thoughts. Just surrender to the raw sensation of the moment, letting it wash over you and carry you away on a tide of pure emotion.

Now imagine you're in a helicopter above the concert. With binoculars, you zoom in and see yourself immersed deeply in the rock concert, immersed in that painful experience. But when you take away the binoculars, you see everyone else at the concert. You can see the band, the lights, and thousands of people. You become a witness to the experience. Instead of being swept up by the emotion, you sit back in your seat and relax behind it, looking at the scene from a distance.

You stay with it. You don't comment. You simply observe it. You see it in its entirety, and then... you let it go. The helicopter departs from the scene. You look back toward the concert as it gets smaller and smaller and then disappears.

You are no longer there. The concert is now in the past. You are here in the present. It's a prior experience. It's not you. And as you let it go:

- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...
- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...
- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...

And you notice that you now feel a little bit lighter.

Look at the fragments of your experience. Were they broken, chipped, shattered? Take a breath. Imagine you're a *kintsugi* master, picking up the

pieces of this experience. As you allow gold to flow through the cracks, what was once pain is now transformed into beauty.

The experience is still part of you, but it no longer defines you. It transforms into something beautiful and strong that will guide you in the next stage of your journey. The transformation not only enriches your life, but by letting go of the past, you are able to make space for the future. With a lighter load, you are much better positioned to discover the work that you are meant to do.

Who Am I Now?

Too often we criticize our prior actions — even those from several years ago — to the point that we let them distort our present experience. Yet the cells in our bodies are replaced daily. In about ninety days, most of your roughly 30 trillion cells will transform into new ones. You are not only a more mature and experienced person with evolved thinking patterns; you are also a biologically different person from who you were several years ago.

If you were exactly the same person you were many years ago, you might be angry with yourself because you may repeat the same behavior. But you are a different person now. Even if you wanted to, replicating the past would be almost impossible. Yes, breathe a huge sigh of relief because the past is over and done with. You will still face challenges, and even if elements of the past repeat, knowing the future will differ from the past should bring you some joy. As your capacity to respond grows, you will have new, richer, and more interesting experiences than ever before.

After even a mildly intense experience, it can be interesting to ponder: Who am I now? How have I evolved? The answer: it's a mystery. You never quite know exactly who you are. All that you can be sure of is that you have grown. Maturity is about accepting the flux of life and recognizing that failure is baked into the process of growth.

How Your Challenges Help You Grow

Rabbi Harold Kushner reflected on the death of his son, who tragically passed away from a rare genetic disease at just fourteen years old. He said:

I'm a more sensitive person, a more effective pastor, a more sympathetic counselor because of Aaron's life and death than I would've been without it. And I would give up all those gains in a second if I could have my son back. If I could choose, I would forego all of the spiritual growth and depth, which has come my way because of our experience. But I cannot choose.

He not only accepted what happened, but he learned from it, grew from it, and moved forward. That's what we want to do now. We must take this difficult experience and move beyond acceptance. We must use it as a springboard to grow.

Viktor Frankl, an Austrian psychiatrist, personifies such growth. While trapped in the atrocities of a concentration camp, he articulated a profound truth with exceptional clarity:

We who lived in concentration camps can remember the men who walked through the huts comforting others, giving away their last piece of bread. They may have been few in number, but they offer sufficient proof that everything can be taken from a person but one thing: the last of the human freedoms — to choose one's attitude in any given set of circumstances, to choose one's own way.

To help survive these atrocious conditions, Frankl wrote notes about his work and hid them in his coat. He was dedicated to his craft for his entire lifetime. He knew what he stood for. For Frankl, psychiatry wasn't merely a profession. It was a calling. He knew that he was sent to do this work. So he did it, and he did it exceptionally well. Indeed, after being freed from the concentration camp, Frankl wrote his groundbreaking book *Man's Search for Meaning* in just nine days.

Sixty-nine years after Viktor Frankl wrote his book, Anthony Ray Hinton was released from prison in another part of the world. After

being framed by the police, Hinton was wrongfully imprisoned for a full thirty years, spending almost his entire time on death row. His Alabama prison cell was infested with rats and cockroaches. He was given scarcely enough food to survive. He spent barely fifteen minutes a day out of his cell. He heard the shrieks of other cellmates being executed in the electric chair. Then the odor of death filled the air, leaving a grim reminder of the execution that occurred just meters away.

How would you respond to these living conditions? While most would lose their composure, Hinton responded with a level of character that we can only hope to emulate, an inimitable ability to transcend the horrific conditions he endured and the gross injustice so mercilessly inflicted upon him. Recounting his experiences, this great man echoed the wisdom of Viktor Frankl, stating:

Despair was a choice. Hatred was a choice. Anger was a choice. I still had choices and that knowledge rocked me... I could choose to give up or to hang on. Hope was a choice. Faith was a choice. And more than anything, love was a choice.

While falsely imprisoned, Hinton established a book club for fellow inmates. After his release, instead of retreating into a private life, Hinton did the opposite. He devoted himself to public speaking, offering hope to those confronted by injustice. His quiet strength and powerful message resonated globally as he harnessed the transformative power of suffering to uplift the lives of others. Hinton's lost years behind bars fueled his public speaking with an intense energy that deeply impacted the lives of those who heard him speak.

Kushner, Frankl, and Hinton each accomplished something very rare. They mastered the art of emotional judo. Judo is the art of using your opponent's weight to redirect their force instead of confronting it head-on. Similarly, emotional judo harnesses negative emotions so that, instead of letting them weaken you, their weight elevates you to a higher level of consciousness. These men transcended their situations by choosing hope over despair, offering us a profound example of how to live.

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These experiences highlight that while there will always be challenges, the inescapable question is: Are you willing to use the force of these difficulties to create a transformation? These experiences are valuable because they give you depth, mold your character, and improve the quality of your thinking. As Camus put it, “In the depths of winter, I finally learned that within me there lay an invincible summer.”

These men also teach us how struggles can become the driving force behind work that is personally fulfilling and valuable to others. Just as Frankl further excelled in psychology and Hinton devoted himself to advocating for justice, you too can establish a new path illuminated by your challenging experiences.

Hopefully, you haven’t endured a fraction of the atrocities faced by Kushner, Frankl, or Hinton. However, if you hadn’t struggled at all, you wouldn’t appreciate the contrast between your past and present. More importantly, you can use these past struggles as seeds to cultivate something beautiful. The pain loses its sting when you absorb its lesson.

This is just the first stage of your journey. Your past challenges are here to help you navigate the next stage.

As the Zen proverb states, *Who knows what is good or bad luck?* It is easy to fall into the trap of believing that getting what you want will create the best experience for you. But more often, it is in the thick of challenging experiences that you uncover hidden gems. It is in these experiences that you break barriers, change perceptions, and create memories that leave an indelible mark on your life.

How to Channel Your Emotions to Build Something Remarkable

When John Wilson was twelve years old, his chemistry class participated in a routine experiment involving boiling water. Unfortunately, a lab assistant had mislabeled a bottle, so instead of boiling water, John boiled a much more reactive substance. The substance caused the container to

explode, shattering many glass bottles. Tragically, John Wilson left that science experiment completely blind.

Most people would be devastated, sink into depression, and lose hope. But John just got on with it. He quickly learned to read Braille, became an accomplished rower, swimmer, and actor, and studied law at Oxford University.

At age twenty-seven, he found himself in Africa. He noticed that blindness was far more prevalent there than in the Western world due to a lack of medical resources. He reflected on how his blindness resulted from an accident and grew angry that millions of others were blind simply due to insufficient resources. Something had to be done, so John established several organizations that helped prevent blindness in tens of millions of people.

If Sir John Wilson could turn his deeply unfortunate experience into a project that helped millions of people, what might be buried in your challenging experience, waiting to be uncovered? Observe the mixture of anger, frustration, and compassion that John felt and how he channeled that energy into something useful. Now, tap into the emotions that your challenges elicit. Feel the emotion deeply. Just as the *kintsugi* artist fills the cracks with gold, use the energy that comes from your challenges to create something that matters to you. Choose the work that fills the cracks with gold.

The Value of Writing About Challenges

When you write about your challenges, you release ideas that were taxing your mind. You expel negative emotions from your body. What once burdened your mind and strained your body now exists in its own place, on its own sheet of paper, separate from you. Now that you are no longer gripped by this narrow emotional focus, you can broaden your gaze and consider related thoughts. This is how you develop perspective.

The more you write, the more your writing reveals to you that you are not your thoughts. You are not your experiences. Your thoughts and

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experiences are separate from you because you are something far greater. You grow to discover that emotions stemming from difficult experiences have a perverse allure, leading you to replay them over and over in your head. But when you write about the experience and let it go, you uncover its hidden value as you progress to the next stage of your growth.

The Hidden Gift

Reflecting on the challenging experience visualized in this chapter:

1. What is the strongest emotion that surfaces when I think about my challenging experience? (e.g., fear, gratitude, relief, frustration)
2. As I sit with this emotion, what emerges as truly important? What have I learned about myself from this experience, and how have I grown from it?
3. Based on what I have learned, what is a project that I would love to pursue?

Duration

Two minutes per question

Feel free to extend this reflection if you're finding it valuable. Writing about challenges can be emotional, so be gentle with yourself. Through this reflection, you're beginning the process of transforming your challenges into sources of strength and insight.

Like the *kintsugi* master carefully mending cracks with gold, you're finding beauty and clarity in your struggles. Let this new perspective guide your choice of work. Perhaps a past experience revealed a hidden strength or highlighted a problem you're now driven to solve. Connect the dots between past and present to envision a project that feels less like a job and more like a calling.

Since this activity is more emotional than others, many find that writing by hand is the best way to complete it.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

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How Do You Pay the Bills and Still Choose Your Work?

The one hour that changes everything.

By now, you might be wondering, “How can I actually afford to do this?” In the last chapter, we saw that some people were willing to make financial sacrifices to choose their work. However, there is a way to both maintain financial security and pursue meaningful work.

Even if you have your finances under control, the uncertainty of drastically changing your day-to-day activities can feel overwhelming. This chapter will provide you with practical strategies on how to make the switch.

A painful mistake to avoid is reacting impulsively to your emotions. You might feel so frustrated by a situation at work that you abruptly quit, only to realize the next day that you don’t have a clear plan. Instead of reacting to strong emotions, force yourself to channel these emotions into writing about how you feel. Then twenty-four hours later, in the light of day, review your reflections and convert them into a plan that moves you forward.

The best approach is to make small and gradual changes. Starting with just one hour each day makes it easy to get started, allowing

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you to build a foundation without sacrificing your financial stability. Before you take the leap, create a financial buffer so that if things don't go as planned, you have a safety net. It's also wise to define your non-negotiable expenses beyond living costs. For example, you may wish to allocate a specific budget to your kids. Create a basic list to ensure that you cover these expenses before taking the leap. Clarity creates freedom. Most importantly, know that you can always find a job if things don't work out.

For more financial strategies, see *Appendix 6: Financial Planning for Choosing Your Work*.

Here are three case studies of ordinary people who made the shift from a job that brought them no joy to choosing work that made them feel fully alive. As you observe their journeys, notice the specific changes they made to choose their work.

Sarah's Story: From Corporate Lawyer to Yoga Studio Owner

Sarah, at forty-three years old, had worked as a corporate lawyer for nineteen years, despite feeling unfulfilled and stressed. She discovered that yoga reduced her anxiety and fell in love with the practice. Sarah started teaching yoga classes on the weekends while still working as a lawyer. She saved money at every opportunity because she realized that she'd rather spend her days in love with yoga than be drained by her legal career. Sarah researched other wellness businesses and used various AI tools to gather insights on marketing and managing a yoga business. She used her research to develop a business plan to open her own yoga studio.

After securing a lease and preparing for months, Sarah quit her legal career and opened her own studio. The first year was challenging, but Sarah's dedication ensured the studio attracted new clients and built a loyal community. She is now grateful every day for the opportunity to share the gift of yoga with her community.

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Sarah chose her work by

- Observing the impact of yoga on her well-being and recognizing it as a viable career choice.
- Teaching yoga on weekends while maintaining her legal job, allowing her to test her interest.
- Saving diligently to build a financial buffer, reducing the financial risk of her career change.
- Conducting research on the wellness industry and developing a comprehensive business plan, leveraging AI tools to gain insights into marketing and managing a yoga business.
- Gradually preparing for the transition by securing a lease and planning months in advance.
- Quitting her legal job only when she felt confident and prepared to run her own business.

Michael's Story: From Fast-Food Worker to Graphic Designer

Michael, at twenty-six years old, had worked at a fast-food restaurant for three years, feeling unfulfilled and knowing his creative strengths were going to waste. He was frustrated that his minimum-wage salary had barely changed despite the clear impact he had made on retaining and growing the restaurant's clientele.

Determined to change, he challenged himself to redesign the logos of random businesses he saw on his commute to work. To achieve this task, he dedicated one hour each evening to learning graphic design through YouTube tutorials. On weekends, he visited the local library to read books on design principles and techniques.

When his beaten-up car broke down and the expensive repair wiped out his savings, he had to work extra shifts to stay afloat. During this period, he couldn't spend an hour each day, but he always did something,

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whether that was a five-minute sketch during his lunch break or a voice note before bed. Michael resolved to choose his work every day in some small way, no matter what.

After recovering from the car repair expense, Michael's routine returned to normal and he started to gain some momentum. He started sharing his improved designs on social media with before-and-after shots. Soon, friends and family began asking him to create logos and flyers. He took on these projects for free at first, building his portfolio and skills.

As his confidence grew, Michael cold-called local businesses, offering his design services at competitive rates. After each call, he reflected on his performance, and in doing so, dramatically improved his sales skills. He woke up an hour earlier each day before his restaurant shifts to work on his craft and further develop his skills. Michael took to heart Steve Martin's line, "Be so good they can't ignore you," and that's exactly what happened.

After months of hard work, Michael built up a solid client base and reduced his restaurant hours to part-time. As his reputation grew, he eventually transitioned to full-time graphic design. Though it was challenging at first, Michael knew he had made the right choice, finally doing work that fulfilled his creative desires.

Michael chose his work by

- Waking up an hour early every day to work on graphic design.
- Using free YouTube tutorials and library books to help him hone his craft.
- Working for free to build his portfolio and skills.
- Developing his voice by sharing his work on social media and engaging with his audience.
- Finding the courage to cold-call small businesses.
- Improving his sales skills through a process of self-reflection.

- Remaining part-time in his job until he had the finances to go full-time in graphic design.

Emily's Story: From Marketing Executive to Children's Book Author

Emily, at sixty-three years old, had worked in marketing for thirty-seven years, climbing the corporate ladder but feeling creatively stifled. She always dreamed of writing children's books but never found the time to pursue it. One day, she stumbled across the stories she wrote for her first child to entertain her at bedtime. Inspired by this memory, she joined a local writing group and started sharing these stories, receiving positive feedback and helpful advice. Emily also volunteered her time to write for causes that aligned with her interests.

Emily committed to writing for two hours every day before work, slowly developing her craft. Over the course of one year, she hired an illustrator and self-published her first book, promoting it through her network. The book gained traction, and Emily landed a publishing deal for a series of children's books. She transitioned to part-time consulting work to focus more on her writing career. Now, Emily feels fulfilled by creating stories that educate and inspire children around the world.

Emily chose her work by

- Using her child's bedtime stories as a creative outlet to explore her passion for writing.
- Joining a local writing group to gain feedback and improve her writing skills.
- Volunteering to write for causes aligned with her interests.
- Committing to writing for two hours daily, consistently dedicating time to her craft.
- Hiring an illustrator and self-publishing her first book to take control of her publishing journey.

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- Leveraging her professional network to promote her book and build an audience.
- Transitioning to part-time work, allowing her to focus more on writing while maintaining financial stability.

Ready to get started? Begin creating your own action plan using the framework provided in *Appendix 1: Action Plan*.

Notice how Emily, Michael, and Sarah all had a bias for action. They faced the discomfort of their current situation without letting technology drown out their challenges. They learned new things but didn't get lost in books or videos. They received advice from others but didn't ruminate endlessly on conversations. Choosing your work is simply a matter of consistently making small changes.

Choosing your work is not reserved for the privileged few. It's a choice available to you if you are willing to embrace discomfort and persistently pursue the work that you are meant to do. It might involve evening or weekend work, but the gift of embracing work that you love far outweighs the sacrifices.

It's Your Turn

Reflect on your own journey. What small steps can you take today to begin choosing your work? Set aside one hour each day to choose your work and, as you gain traction, gradually expand from there.

Schedule the hour when you're most productive, in an enjoyable location, to emphasize the significance of this time. Here are five things you can do to ensure that you take action.

1. **Decide on a specific location.** You are significantly more likely to engage in this work if you decide in advance exactly where you will do it. The actual location does not matter; it could be a simple desk or a café. By consistently working from the same location, you signal to your brain that it's time to enter a focused

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creative state, much like the stage indicates to an actor that it's showtime.

2. **Schedule a time when you know you won't be interrupted.** Personally, I am at my best in the mornings. If I only had an hour, it would be the first hour of the morning. I have found that if I begin with "busy work," my mind gets cluttered and it's hard to get in the creative zone. Some coders get in the zone at midnight. Choose your time and protect it.
3. **Begin with a ritual.** Something as simple as making a cup of tea or loading a specific playlist reinforces the beginning of your ritual and reduces the chance of getting distracted. For me, it's putting my phone on Do Not Disturb in the corner of my room and covering it with a book.
4. **Adopt a non-negotiable mindset.** If you are a teacher, you have to show up to teach your classes. If you are a doctor, you must show up for your scheduled appointments. The significance of your journey justifies treating this hour with the same dedication.
5. **Journal your wins.** As you make progress, journal your wins. Include positive feedback, meaningful insights, small victories, unexpected wins, and self-reflections. During moments of uncertainty and frustration, refer to your journal to remind yourself why you are committed to your work and how far you have already come on this journey.

Here are some things you can do in that hour.

- **Start a new project related to the work you are currently doing.** Sometimes the work that you are meant to do is in the same field that you are currently in; it's just that you need to do something different. In your current field, is there a book that you want to write, a podcast that you'd like to start, or an app that you'd like to build? Choose something and begin it today.

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- **Begin with a service.** A service is a great starting point because it gives you the chance to personally understand the problem you are seeking to solve. Build your portfolio and get testimonials from satisfied clients. Start with small projects and then gradually take on more challenging assignments. Consider delivering presentations or even offering workshops.
- **Consider converting services into products.** You may wish to one day convert your services into products so that you can scale your impact to a larger audience. If, after offering a service, you have helped someone produce a result, consider converting your paid service into a paid online course. Creating a course requires unpaid work, but it's something you do once and can use forever. Then, when you do consulting, you can entice prospects with free access to the course as part of your service.
- **Use projects to help you grow.** Take online courses, attend workshops, and read books to develop skills relevant to your chosen field. New ideas are valuable, but spend more time applying knowledge than acquiring it. You'll make far more progress when your focus is on taking action. Only seek resources when you're stuck. Investing weeks in a course that does not move an active project forward is often a waste of time.
- **Become a Sales Grandmaster.** Sales Grandmasters never appear to be selling. Their key strength is their ability to listen and understand the intricacies of a person's challenge. When a potential client feels like you understand their problem more deeply than anyone else, you automatically become the solution. There's much more to learn, but whatever field you choose, learning to sell will always be a wise investment.
- **Research those who have achieved the result that you are seeking to achieve.** New copywriters and painters are trained to replicate, word for word or stroke by stroke, the greatest ads, letters, and artworks ever created. The goal is not to plagiarize, but

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instead to relive elite experiences. Use this training as inspiration to diligently examine the work of the people whom you admire. This is called mimetic learning, the process of learning through imitation. It works.

- **Use your favorite AI tool to get some guidance.** Use a prompt like: *I take photos as a hobby and I really love it. How can I monetize this so that I leave my boring corporate job and start working every day as a photographer?* Don't stop at the answer. Have a conversation with the AI, and it will often provide valuable coaching. Then have a similar conversation with other AIs to sharpen your perspective.

One early reader of this book said she loved this chapter but would have liked more specifics on what to do next. While I've done my best to provide practical suggestions with the bullets above and the step-by-step guide in Appendix 1, I told her that, above all, you need to create your own path. In a job, you are told what to do. You need to arrive on time, complete your tasks, and then you can go home. But this is different. You need to design the plan. Hopefully, the reflective prompts at the end of each chapter will help spark insights, but don't expect anyone to give you every answer. Take what resonates with you and then create your own roadmap.

As you move forward, expect things *not* to go as planned. Planning is very helpful because it gets you to think, and thinking creates valuable ideas. But the actual plan that you create becomes outdated as soon as it's finished. Each week, spend at least an hour reviewing the big picture and updating your master plan. At a minimum, ask these questions for your upcoming week:

1. What went well last week? What wins can I build on?
2. What were my challenges last week? What needs attention?
3. What are my top priorities for this week?

The 1-1-1 Rule: *One* hour. *One* location. *One* project.

If you take only one action from this book, adopt the 1-1-1 rule.

- Schedule *one* hour at the same time each day to choose your work.
- Work from *one* location to signal to your brain that it's time to enter a focused creative state.
- Work on just *one* project, and don't begin a new project until this project is complete.

Do this for 90 days and watch your life change. Yes, I know you have a lot on and it's hard to make time for one hour. Do it anyhow. *Your commitment to spend one hour per day is the one choice that changes everything.*

To kickstart this process, I have created a tracker that you can use to help you develop a lasting habit. You can download it for free at: ChooseYourWorkBook.com/tracker

So Is This as Easy as One Hour per Day?

Another reader asked, "How do I balance choosing my work with my current job that keeps me housed and fed?" After some discussion, it became clear she knew all she needed to do was to follow the 1-1-1 Rule, but she couldn't bring herself to do it.

Everything has a price. Many crave the feeling of vitality, but few are prepared to exercise regularly and choose a nutritious diet. Many want financial independence, but few are prepared to begin an uncertain project, work relentless hours, and deal with multiple failures. Many seek fulfilling relationships, but few are prepared to develop emotional intelligence, apologize for communication errors, and seek better ways to relate to others. So when it comes to choosing your work, are you prepared to make the sacrifices needed so that your life will be centered on the thing that you love?

HOW DO YOU PAY THE BILLS AND STILL CHOOSE YOUR WORK?

If you truly and deeply love your work, you will gladly suffer for it. You will give up some of the pleasures of consumption to engage in the joy of creation.

My love of writing this book was tested multiple times. While I was writing, I would think, “This is pretty decent.” But the next morning, I’d review it in the light of day, and more often than not, I would say to myself, kindly but firmly, “This is not good enough. This is not at the standard it needs to be.” So I’d delete large sections, I’d edit, I’d refine, and I’d interrogate my assumptions. Slowly, slowly, the writing started to resemble a first draft.

Then I gave the book to over one hundred beta readers. They highlighted areas needing improvement, pointed out inaccuracies, and offered constructive feedback. I reflected deeply on why and how I fell short so as to find a path to move forward. It was painful, uplifting, and necessary to see my errors and omissions.

Progress is only possible through a conversation with pain.

Embrace the pain. Search for the pain. The pain is your friend. It is where the magic begins.

So is this as easy as one hour per day? No, it’s as difficult as one hour per day. Do you love your work enough to embrace the beautiful difficulty?

Now, grab your calendar and spend literally two minutes on the activity below.

The Hour of Possibility

- 1. When is the best time to spend one hour exploring new ideas for my work?*
- 2. Choose a time and place each day and block out your calendar.*

Duration

Two minutes

If you consistently dedicate just one hour a day to exploring new possibilities, your life will positively change.

This reflection is less about thinking and more about taking action. Open your calendar and schedule a recurring one-hour block dedicated to exploring new work ideas. Make this time non-negotiable and ensure it is sacred, distraction-free time. Check the box when you have completed this task.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

-

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Praise for *Choose Your Work*

Choose Your Work is both deeply personal and profoundly universal. It is insightful, provocative, and quietly unsettling. It seamlessly blends research and real-world anecdotes with practical, step-by-step guidance to help you identify what matters most. This is a book for anyone who has ever sensed there must be more — more meaning, more joy, more alignment between who they are and the work they do.

Genia Janover | Award-Winning Former Principal | Bialik College | Former Fellow | Australian College of Educators

Dan Dobos says the scary, quiet thing out loud: how we spend our working lives is a choice. *Choose Your Work* is both a wake-up call and a practical roadmap for anyone ready to make that choice.

Ben Stickland | Co-Founder & CEO | Instamove

This is the kind of book I will go back to regularly. Some self-help books you read once. Others bring value over and over throughout your life. This is the latter.

Teshia Harding

Choose Your Work distills a lifetime of insights and wisdom into a practical guide to help you clarify what matters most.

Jonar Nader | Former IBM Executive | Author of *How to Lose Friends & Infuriate Your Boss*

Chapter Two alone helped me more than therapy has.

Kayla Giles

Choose Your Work is a timely and deeply needed guide for anyone who senses there must be more to work than simply earning a living. In a volatile world that pushes people toward conformity, this book offers a practical and thought-provoking path back to what truly matters.

Mark Bowles | Dean, Tasmanian School of Business and Economics | University of Tasmania

In my work as a psychotherapist, I see how easy it is to lose sight of who you truly are. *Choose Your Work* offers a thoughtful and compelling path back to yourself.

Kirk Fisher | Psychotherapist & Zen Teacher

Honest, raw, and real. *Choose Your Work* was exactly what I needed.

Christy Oshima

Unlike other career change manuals, this is a guide for those searching for fulfilling work that is both optimistic and encouraging.

Helen Praetz | Emeritus Professor and Former Pro Vice-Chancellor | RMIT University

If you know someone graduating college, buy them this book. If a friend just turned 30, buy them this book. Most people stumble into careers that 'kinda work' and there they remain stuck. Don't be like most people. Buy this book.

James Tuckerman | Founder | Anthill Magazine

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**Have you ever felt the unnerving sensation that,
despite appearing successful, something deep down isn't quite right?**

When you look back at your life, will you be satisfied?
Or will you have regrets?

The dark side of grit is chasing goals that don't matter,
while your deepest desires quietly fade away.

The way forward is to realize that the secret to a
fulfilling life is to choose your work.

**In this thought-provoking book, packed with inspiration,
practical strategies, and insightful stories, you will discover...**

What is more valuable than \$100 million in cold hard cash?

•

How to extract insights from your greatest challenges to realize your potential

•

Strategies to choose your work while still paying the bills

•

Why being good at something may lead you down the
wrong path and how to find the right one

•

Why focusing on comfort can ruin your life and
obscure the true metrics of success



**This book will help you discover your deepest truth, redefine what
success means to you, and begin a fulfilling new chapter in your journey.**

"Compelling and thought-provoking. It inspired immediate action in my life."

Beau Florenosos

"Inspirational, memorable and unlike any self-help book I've read before."

Jean Rose Dogillo

"Engaging, energising and deeply thought-provoking."

Liz Treat